Although the *Matsya Purana* places the first Satakarni sixth in the line of Satavahana kings, the other Puranas all put him third and name him as successor to Kanha, brother of Simuka. A Jain text translated by Professor Bühler states that Simuka, founder of the Satavahana dynasty, was a great builder of Buddhist and Jain temples but became so tyrannical that he was killed by his younger brother Kanha. This led Bühler to conclude that this Raja Simuka was the ruler named and portrayed in the Naneghat Cave, as well as being the Satavahana king named in the Hathigumpha inscription against whom the Jain ruler of Kalinga, Raja Kharavela, went to war in about 166 BCE.

Most modern historians consider Bühler's dating to be a century too early, although the case is by no means proven. This majority view holds that the early Satavahana rulers suffered a setback but bounced back in the first half of the first century BCE, with the first Raja Satakarni playing a leading role in restoring and extending Satavahana rule. The *Matsya Purana* credits him with ruling for a remarkable fifty-six years, which is so unusual as to suggest that it has a solid basis in fact. He or some other early Satavahana ruler with the same name certainly suffered a defeat at the hands of Raja Kharavela of Kalinga, after which came a series of victories, first over the Shungas or their successors, the Kanvas, to the north, and then the Indo-Greeks (the so-called Western Satraps) in the north-west. This opened the way up and over the Naneghat Pass and on to Pratisthana, situated on the upper reaches of the Godavari River in the Aurangabad District of Maharashtra. Pratisthana then became the Satavahanas' northern capital – today Paithan, south of Aurangabad, best known for its hand-woven Paithani saris (see Map 7).